

CROSSROADS

A classless, gritty narrative system about who you become in the world that breaks you.

What is Crossroads?

Crossroads is a story driven TTRPG about moral and ethical choices, diplomacy, growth, and the scars it leaves on the characters. Instead of levels or classes, your character grows through paths and marks. Its about a group of people telling stories together.

You will not slay thousands of monsters or collect hordes of treasure. There are no experience points or hit points. No giant character sheets filled with combat abilities with long descriptions and niche interactions. Crossroads is filled with Character development. It is a roleplaying game, weighted towards roleplay. You will make choices that define who you are and what remains thereafter. The rules are there to enhance the narrative, not stifle it.

The reason for this systems existence was my ever-growing annoyance with the gameplay loop of Dungeons and Dragons and Pathfinder, where 95% of the rules and abilities are combat focused. In return the trifurcated nature of TTRPGs, being Combat, Exploration and Social, ended up heavily weighted towards combat. In a lot of ways, DnD tempts players to start combat, to seek out ways to use their giant character sheets and cool abilities. DnD might be a good wargame, I'd say its okay, but it is not good for the 2/3rds of the totality of the typical TTRPG experience.

Crossroads takes a different approach, where the rules take a backseat to the experience of roleplay. I want the rules to strengthen character development, not combat. Combat in Crossroads is treated as any other encounter, to be solved and overcome, not with miniatures and maps, but with wit and will. Skill challenges and Trait rolls are the core of all scenes in Crossroads. In DnD combat is slow and tactical. In crossroads its fast paced and leaves lasting scars.

The Basics.

Dice: d10 system

Tone: Gritty, low magic, morally gray

Focus: Politics, diplomacy, sacrifice, character growth

What you need: 4 blank pieces of A4 paper, pencil, eraser, two 10-sided dice.

The Character Sheet

Your sheet has six parts.

Name and origin.

Paths (3)

Traits (Mind, Body and Spirit)

Marks (permanent consequences, good or bad)

Bonds (People, factions or ideals)

Notable Talents (The niche things you are specifically good at)

Paths

At the start, make 3 paths. They can be ideals, goals, emotions, or moral stances. Each should be short, personal and evocative. Remember, they are going to be with you for a long time. They need to be deeply intertwined with your character.

Write each path at the bottom of a blank piece of paper. Every time you gain a mark, draw a line out from the path and write the name of the mark and how you got it. On the other side of the paper, write down the mark and what it does.

By the end you will have a long path of marks that show every significant choice you made. If you so wish you can also add another line and show the choice you didn't make, this will give the result a feeling of a set of crossroads to look back on.

Examples

1. ***Path of the Shepherd:*** I protect those who cannot protect themselves
2. ***Path of the Broker:*** Everyone has a price, everything is negotiation.
3. ***Path of the Convict:*** Crime is in the eye of the beholder.
4. ***Path of the Flame:*** It is by divine right I make my choice.
5. ***Path of Vengeance:*** You are driven by a personal vendetta
6. ***Path of the Broken:*** I survived a traumatic event and live every day to make sure no one else must experience it.
7. ***Path of the Noble:*** I live high class; I am high class. Mud is for swine as bread is for peasants.

During play your character will face situations where the **paths** you have chosen will come into play. You or the GM may invoke a specific **path** related to a scene, where your choice in the scene will leave a **Mark** (A lasting consequence)

Each path evolves differently depending on your choices. There are no premade fixtures in Crossroads.

Example:

The Player is playing Threna with *Path of Vengeance* (Her father was killed by the empress and now she seeks revenge)

GM: Before you stand the grand Empress, she who sentenced your father to death many years ago. You have been waiting for this moment for a long time.

Player: I am going to invoke the *path of vengeance* and attack her in anger.

The GM asks for a Trait rolls or skill challenges which ends in one way or another. Depending on what happens the character gains a mark that fits with the choice made and the result of the choice. This is usually a mechanical buff or debuff, change in reputation, a fracture, or just narrative fluff.

Should the player choose to not attack the Empress, then a different mark will be given or a Path Fracture is invoked.

Marks

After choosing a path when the GM asks for it, you gain a mark. A mark is both a narrative and mechanical vehicle. It changes who you are and how you play.

Example

Mark of Loss (Major Wound Mark): You chose to defend someone in need, but now your character lost an eye. You have -3 when making a Mind check to perceive something. You have gained the respect of the poor in X region, gain a bond with them.

Mark of Deceit: You chose to lie in a critical moment and now gain a +1 to *Mind* checks when lying in the future. Lying now comes easier to you as truth is losing meaning.

Mark of Conviction: After beating down a thief stealing bread to survive you have become a stalwart defender of the law, but at what cost? People now fear you. Nuance has become a thing of the past; your world turns ever blacker and whiter.

Notice that not every mark gives a + to a trait but rather aims to give bonuses or minuses depending on situations. You can gain abilities, or bonds or grit or reputation

Wound Marks

Wound Marks are a specific type of mark that occur when a character for whatever reason sustains some sort of injury. They are marked as normal on the paths, but are special in that they mark specific bodily or mental harm. They can occur due to combat, torture, disaster, accidents, etc. Wound Marks come in three flavours: Minor, Major and Mortal.

Minor

For example, a broken rib, a deep laceration, concussion, or a burn. Usually combined with a minor negative effect that is situational. For example, a -1 to body checks when climbing, if you broke your wrist. These can usually be healed over time and leaves a scar of some kind.

Major

Losing body parts, functionally destroyed limbs, puncturing lungs. Anything that is not just temporary or visual. Something that deeply affects the character and shapes their existence. Usually combined with a major negative effect that can only be partially healed or fixed over time. Losing an eye -3 to any sight-based activity.

Mortal

Mortal wounds like internal bleeding, impalement, a cut throat, execution. These may arise when the character fails something incredibly dangerous, a specific path is invoked, like for example that of a sacrifice, or the character has an accumulation of several severe wounds. These mortal wounds trigger a death scene.

Death Scene

Death scenes are a collaborative effort between the player and DM where they play out a character's death. A player gets to describe how their character dies or are permanently out of the game.

A death scene is a singular scene; a last conversation, a confession, a choice that defies legacy, one final path invocation. Imagine Theoden dying in Return of the King. That last beautiful moment between him and his daughter. That is what a death scene is.

Traits

You have three traits:

Mind: This is your knowledge, wit, awareness and deceit

Body: This is your endurance, might, reflexes, suffering,

Spirit: This is your conviction, empathy, will, charisma, insight

You have a 3, 2 and 1 to assign as you please. When you attempt something that has the possibility to fail, the GM will ask for you to roll a d10 and add the number from the relevant trait against the difficulty table.

7-9: partial success

10+: you succeed fully

Less than 6: You fail

Skill Challenges

A lot of in world scenes might end up in scenarios where a lot of rolling or slowing down of momentum incurs. A chase scene, escaping a burning building, combat. These are solved with Skill Challenges. A skill challenge is a set of 3 Trait rolls that determine the outcome of the task at hand. The combination of fails, partial successes, and successes, determines how the challenge goes. In group activities the GM can use the average of what is rolled for each of the three trait checks.

Lineage

Lineage is your specific roots. Who your family is, what city, what nation, who your ancestors are. Together with your GM, connect your character to the world through their lineage. It is recommended to find some ties to important happenings in the world. If you know there was a revolution recently in a city, why not tie yourself to that. Be a part of the revolution, or someone close to those dethroned, or maybe someone on the sideline who got caught in the middle. You can tie this to your [bonds](#), or just use them to give your character ties to the world. After the lineage is created, the GM can choose to adjust certain [reputations](#) in the world according to the lineage.

Make a name for your lineage so that it's easy to remember and to give it a bit of flair.

Magic

Magic in Crossroads is a bit nebulous thing. Crossroads is not intended to be a high magic system with lots of rules. The point is to not be bogged down by tons of text and hypertextual referencing and rules lawyering, but rather a collective storytelling system. So this is more of a recommendation than a hard rule. If a player chooses to play a spellcaster. Make that into a path. Path of the spellcaster or something adjacent or related to that. This path opens marks that will let you influence the world around you through magical abilities. These can be totally homebrewed and unique to the character who is playing.

Notable Talents

Chose two notable talents your character has. Make them specific to an interest or topic. When rolling a trait check pertaining to your notable talents you can add +1. As you progress through the campaign, the notable talents become better on the GMs discretion. You can also gain notable talents through marks.

A notable talent can be, juggling, singing, carpentry, persuasion, sprinting, horse riding, swordplay, chemistry, and so much more.

Advantage and Disadvantage

Whenever you make a roll that would go against or in alignment with your bonds, or if the GM thinks it applicable, you can be asked to roll with disadvantage or advantage. This takes the form of rolling a d10 twice and taking either the lower (disadvantage) or the higher roll (advantage)

Bonds

You begin with 2 bonds. A bond ties you to someone, somewhere or something in the world. You will gain and lose bonds over time. A bond can give you advantage or disadvantage on a Trait roll depending on if you are acting in alignment with the bond. So, if you owe someone your life, and later have to kill them, you make the **Body** check with disadvantage. Equally if you are rolling to save them, you roll with advantage.

Bonds are a liquid thing, and you might end up with no bonds or 10 bonds depending on how the story unfolds.

Fractures

Sometimes during play, you end up deciding against a path or bond. If a bond fractures, you lose the bond and gain a fracture mark. If you fracture a path, the old path becomes inactive and a new path, co-created with you and the GM, comes into play. This is the bread and butter of Crossroads. The idea of the pivotal moment where you must decide between left and right.

Path Fracture Example: A holy priest deciding to abandon his faith for evil. Losing Path of the Holy and gaining Path of the Dark One. This should be marked on your paths sheet as a clear deviation.

A pacifist deciding to use violence. Losing Path of the Pacifist and gaining Path of the Ethically Unsure

Threna with Path of Vengeance not killing the baron would maybe fracture her path and start a new pat; Path of the Merciful.

Bond Fracture Example:

Player A has a bond with his father. The father is wanted by the state for treason and will be executed, there is a big reward. Player A gives up his father's position to the state who is looking for said father. The player loses the bond with the father and gains a **Fracture Mark**.

Fracture Mark of Patricide.

Player character has reputation with family and local community set to hated. Player character has rumours spread about them that will make trust hard to come by

Grit

Each player starts the campaign with 3 grit. These can be used to reroll a Trait dice once. Gaining grit is very difficult and only happens through gaining marks. You might never gain more grit. You might gain a few. Be careful not to waste them on small things.

Grit is one of the few abilities that can help you avoid wound marks when attempting something mortally risky, so be sure not to waste them.

Reputation

Keep track of how factions view you. There are five levels: Loved, Trusted, Tolerated, Disliked, Hated. Each choice might shift one faction's stance.

When playing these functions as a tracker for yourself and the DM. Rolls to persuade a faction or person depends on the reputation the character has to said faction or person. Below is a table of bonuses the DM can use.

Loved +3

Trusted +1

Tolerated 0

Disliked - 1

Hated – 3

Survival - Pressure Points

Survival in Crossroads is meant to enhance the vehicles for roleplay that is already there. It does not aim to bog down the game with lots of minute details like encumbrance and ounces of food.

A character has 5 pressures. Each of these pressures range from 1-3. 1 meaning it is a mild strain, 2 is deprivation and 3 meaning it is in danger of killing them.

Food ()

Water ()

Temperature ()

Stress ()

Comfort ()

When a party is in a survival situation, failure and partial successes will give pressure points to characters. If the party fails to find food, gather wood, find shelter, they gain +2. If it is a partly success, they gain +1. If it is a success, they gain 0.

A party member with 6 pressure points reaches a breaking point. Breaking points are -1 net negatives to all rolls. When you have gained a breaking point, every two additional pressure points over 6 add a breaking point. When a character reaches 10 pressure points it triggers a collapse scene. Collapse scenes are at a point where characters must succeed a skill challenge or gain minor, major or mortal wound marks depending on amount of successes on the skill challenge.

Character example

Name: Tihar “Teel” Knuckledragger Name

Origin: Factory worker and ex union buster

Traits: Mind 1, Body 3, Spirit 2

Paths:

Path of the Proletariat: You are a hard-working everyday man. You find trust in the common struggles and understand those of lower class.

Path of the Repentant: You used to be a union buster and are trying to repent for those violent sins.

Path of the Revolutionary: The workers of the sootworks need a voice and a leader and you believe yourself to be a just one.

Bonds:

Caucasian Female (A childhood friend and fellow worker)

The Overseer (A man deserving the death sentence)

Notable Talents:

Carpentry

Reading